

IN NEED FOR SOME ASIAN INSPIRATION

After a decade of ISL, **what more can be done** to help Indian football grow?

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The Indian Super League (ISL) started 10 years ago with hopes of emulating the success of the Indian Premier League (IPL) in cricket.

However, it has not had the wide-ranging impact it intended in order to lift Indian football out of its quagmire.

India, the 1952 Asian Games champion, is now ranked 126th, its lowest in seven years. Despite having a league structure with 13 teams and no relegation, Indian football has failed to rise up the Asian standings.

"I'm very optimistic about this season for FC Goa, but I'm not very optimistic about the continuity of the ISL. This is my feeling — changing

14-15 players is not a problem for the players or the coach, but it is a problem within the system. We can speak 1,000 hours about it," said a pragmatic Manolo Marquez, head coach of the Indian men's national team, in a recent interview.

So, how can Indian football learn and grow beyond its leagues? Perhaps some of its Asian counterparts may present an answer.

The ISL is a market worth INR 467 crores, ranking 12th among the 17 Asian countries (whose data is available) that are ranked above India in the current FIFA rankings.

It has attracted global superstars such as Roberto Carlos and



Tough talk: "I'm not very optimistic about the continuity of the ISL. This is my feeling — changing 14-15 players is not a problem for the players or the coach, but it is a problem within the system" — Manolo Marquez. AIFF MEDIA

Japan's 100-year plan, initiated in 1992, has yielded results both on and off the field, with Vietnam and Thailand fully embracing the Japanese philosophy.